

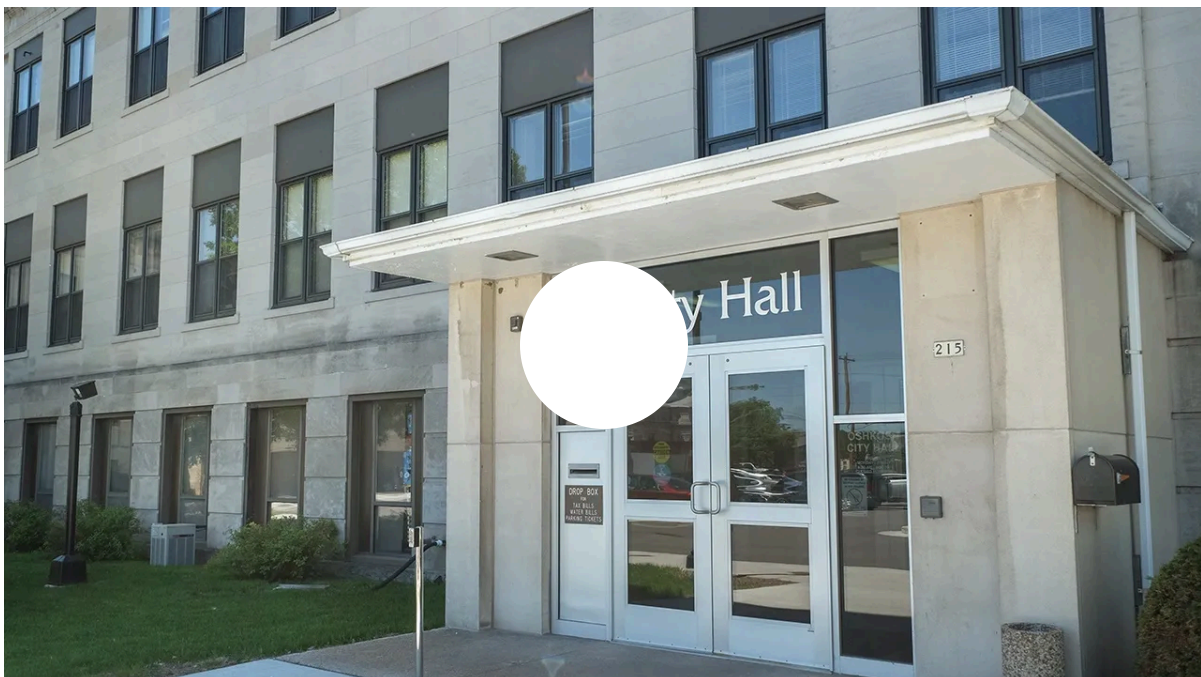


Advertisement - scroll for more content

Oshkosh drops Flock cameras after chief raises trust and access issues

The reversal came less than 24 hours after the council had initially approved a one-year renewal amid community pushback.

[JUSTIN MARVILLE](#) Oshkosh Northwestern



Show Caption ▾



- The decision was made after the Oshkosh Police Department stated the company misrepresented information about the cameras' capabilities.
- Concerns from the public included privacy erosion, data sharing, and potential misuse by law enforcement.
- The reversal came less than 24 hours after the council had initially approved a one-year renewal amid community pushback.

(This story has been updated to add the latest information.)

OSHKOSH – The city's [Flock era](#) has come to an end.

Oshkosh is rescinding its agreement with [Flock Safety](#) after [Oshkosh Police Department](#) said the company misrepresented information regarding the automated license plate readers at the April 21 Common Council meeting.

Dig deeper: [Milwaukee homicide suspect caught in Oshkosh using Flock technology](#)

Faced with serious concerns from OPD Chief Dean Smith, city council voted unanimously not to renew the contract less than 24 hours after approving an amended one-year agreement with Flock.

What led to Smith's issues with Flock Safety?

Addressing Common Council at a special April 22 meeting, Smith said he was immediately advised by officers that Flock cameras create a “heat map,” directly refuting claims to the contrary from Flock Chief Information Security Officer Chris Castaldo.

Oshkosh views on Flock: [Flock yeah? Flock no? Oshkosh split on Flock camera resolution.](#)



Castaldo told councilor Brad Spanbauer the images captured by Flock cameras do not create a pattern of movement for vehicles while also claiming federal agencies couldn't access Oshkosh's data without OPD's knowledge.

Saying "integrity and trust is important to us all," Smith said he met with City Manager Rebecca Grill and advised city staff to immediately revoke the contract.

Oshkosh now joins regional municipalities in Verona, Sturgeon Bay and Dane County in moving on from the contentious license plate readers.

Advertisement

Are the Flock cameras still active?

Assistant Chief of Police Brian Schuldes advised the Northwestern that the OPD will be powering off each of Oshkosh's 26 Flock cameras on April 23 while covering the license plate readers with a bag to ensure they cannot collect data.

Schuldes also revealed that any access by outside agencies has been revoked while all internal users have had their accounts deactivated with the exception of the city's Flock Administrator.



The decision to reverse course came as a shocking turn of events, happening less than one full day after Oshkosh voted in favor of retaining the license plate readers despite numerous public outbursts amid major community pushback.

Common Council did initially opt to shorten the initial two-year, \$163,500 contract proposal to a one-year deal, taking into account public comments on the floor at the April 21 meeting by proposing the establishment of a committee to review the Flock contract.

But that came after community members stormed out of the meeting following no fewer than two public outbursts where one person screamed “liar, liar” at Castaldo.

How did the public react to the city rescinding the Flock contract?

The mood of Wednesday’s session was significantly more tranquil with 13 community members praising Smith for his humility, honesty and transparency in revealing the discrepancy in public.

Deputy Mayor Karl Buelow even apologized to the community for “making the wrong decision” before council voted in unison to end the one-year deal.

What are Flock cameras and what are they used for?

Solar-powered cameras, Flock Safety readers are essentially tools mounted on poles used to capture the rear of vehicles and analyze license plates to provide other vehicle data in a system.



The company's client base is composed of more than 5,000 law enforcement agencies, who can search the system for plate numbers, vehicle color, vehicle type or a distinguishable feature to receive real-time alerts tracking stolen automobiles or vehicles associated with warrants or a crime.

Oshkosh previously deployed 26 of those Flock cameras across city streets, with council unanimously approving their implementation in 2022 through a state grant covered by Gov. Tony Evers' COVID relief funds.

Why did community members oppose Flock cameras?

The renewal would have come at a cost to the city while the public pointed to concerns about possible infringement of Fourth Amendment rights, privacy erosion, security vulnerabilities, the company's data sharing and law enforcement misuse.

In February, Mountain View City Council in California terminated its contract with Flock after an investigation revealed more than 250 unapproved agencies conducted around 600,000 searches of the city's records over the span of a year.

Both Milwaukee and Menasha have also seen police officers charged after using the Flock system to personally track vehicles belonging to women.

Was there public support for Flock cameras in Oshkosh?

A recent reader callout showed Northwestern readership being [split down the middle on Flock cameras](#), with supporters referencing cases that were solved because of the automated license plate readers.

Just hours before an April 15 community-led discussion, OPD said a Milwaukee suspect listed among Wisconsin's Most Wanted [was arrested in Oshkosh through an investigation that used Flock cameras](#).



narcotics, and the perpetrators of a pair of hit-and-run cases.

OPD also has a Flock Transparency Portal under its Policies and Procedures that outlines personal use amid concerns of law enforcement misuse.

Contact Justin Marville at jmarville@usatodayco.com and follow him on X (formerly Twitter) at @justinmarville.



Advertisement

[Help](#) · [Terms of Service](#) · [Subscription Terms & Conditions](#) · [Privacy Policy](#) · [Site Map](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Our Ethical Principles](#) · [Responsible Disclosure](#) ·  [Your Privacy Choices](#)

